

"Like *The Life of Christ*, we shall make pictures on Ram, Krishna, their Ayodhya and Gokul."

FIRST SHOWMAN

Fascinated by industrial techniques and inspired by a swadeshi impulse to create nationalist images, the father of Indian cinema's mingling of religion and politics has become a fundamental trait of the country's public culture

Dhundiraj Govind Phalke

Filmmaker 1870-1944

■ By Suresh Chabria

Though energised by a near messianic zeal to establish an indigenous film industry in colonial India, even D.G. Phalke would be surprised by the overwhelming cultural supremacy—or at least the ubiquity—of cinema and television today. His project, conceived as a fusion of artisanal impulses, fascination with modernity as well as industrial techniques and a swadeshi-inspired desire to create Indian images for Indian audiences, has translated into the writing and making of history. Culture historians acknowledge this as the lasting legacy of Phalke and other pioneers of popular Indian visual art.

Born in a Maharashtrian Brahmin family in 1870 and educated at Bombay's J.J. School of Art and Baroda's Kalabhavan, he learnt drawing, photography, lithography and drama before joining Raja Ravi Varma's press in Lonavala. He also learnt magic, which he later considered an essential qualification for filmmakers. A naturally gifted entrepreneur, he soon established his own printing and engraving press in Bombay and produced chromolithographs as well as illustrated booklets that were to become the blueprint of his early mythological films.

In 1910, he saw a film titled *The Life of Christ* and described its im-

